

INDIRA GANDHI NATIONAL OPEN UNIVESITY



A success story in education and training

The 11th plan has brought a new era in education. The plan has proposed unprecedented 10 fold increase in outlay for higher education. The target has been set of having access rate of 15 for higher education by 2012 from current 10%. The plan lays emphasis on skill, capacity building, training, employability, lifelong education and continuing education. Open and Distance learning has been recognized and accepted as important mode of achieving many of these targets. The Open education system in the country, under the DEC comprises of IGNOU, 13 state open universities, over 150 Distance education institutes in conventional universities and National Institute of Open Schooling with a countrywide network of open school units.

Indira Gandhi National Open University (IGNOU), during its 22 years of existence, has played a major role in this qualitative and quantitative expansion of the higher education system. In the year 2007, its annual, fresh enrolment crossed 5 lakhs and cumulative student strength is about 1.8 million now, which is 15% of the total student population in the universities in India. About 300 new study centres and 8 more regional centres of the University have been started in 2007.

Realising the challenges of this rapid expansion, several measures have been taken in 2007 to strengthen the learner support systems. In addition to ensuring the minimum necessary infrastructural facilities, steps are being taken to provide broadband connectivity to all the study centres. On the technology side of course delivery, from 1st December, 2007, supplementing the self-learning materials and academic counselling, IGNOU's educational programmes are reaching over 5 million homes through the Gyan Darshan Channels, via the DTH (Direct-To-Home) platform. Considering the significant role of technology-augmented conventional face-to-face education, open and distance learning, satellite education and online education in enhancing the quality of the teaching learning process and in expanding the reach of education with social inclusivity, a new scheme on convergence of ODL systems with the conventional patterns of education in the traditional universities and affiliated colleges was launched by IGNOU and DEC on the 22nd Foundation Day of the University on 19th November, 2007, by the Minister for Human Resource Development, Mr. Arjun Singh. The response to the new scheme is enormous.

In a talk Prof. V. N. Rajasekharan Pillai, Vice-Chancellor of Indira Gandhi National Open University (IGNOU), New Delhi and Chairman of the Distance Education Council (DEC), shares his vision and mission on taking ODL and university to newer heights. "We need to strengthen quality assurance at the systemic levels of teaching, learning and governance. Autonomy with accountability at individual and functional unit levels,

decentralisation, distributed creation of infrastructure across the country, strengthening and capacity building of administrative staff, increased use of technological tools to serve the pedagogical requirements, and above all, a very sensitive and responsible student support service system, need to be implemented for us to continue as an effective partner in achieving inclusive growth of the country through inclusive education" he says.

"The role of technology augmented conventional face to face education, open and distance learning, satellite education and online education in enhancing the quality of the teaching-learning process and in expanding the reach of education with social inclusivity is enormous..." shares Dr Pillai, highlighting the plans for creating a national ICT (information and Communication Technologies) infrastructure for networking for open and distance learning (ODL). This is one area that IGNOU is looking in, in-addition to opening a large number of open schools. Another major point that he emphasizes is on the standardization of the quality parameters of the education for which DEC is proposing to the government a national open testing service for assessing ODL students. The norms for this he says will be set by the stakeholders in the corporate sector, people from the working area and experts from academia. This testing service will ensure evaluation and assessment of the students what is the level of his achievement, skill, knowledge etc.

Dr Pillai informs that IGNOU alongwith DEC is also working to create an assessment and accreditation mechanism. As of now, DEC and AICTE are looking at recognized courses. DEC is also working towards providing a National Qualification Framework that will facilitate concept transfer from one system to another. By facilitating the academic and professional mobility from one sector to another a hallmark of the quality education system is created.

DEC is looking at several criteria like institutional mechanism, teaching learning process, how technology is used, student outcome, industry relevance and industry intake. This will be not aimed at ranking institution amongst A, B or C rather it would be a SWOT analysis.

As he summarizes, he reiterates that Distance Education is not a correspondence education, rather is a technology assisted conventional system of education. The overall purpose is to increase the quality of education, with an attempt to guide the students for self learning methods. This is helping in the development of additional capabilities and the quantity of education delivery will be enhanced to increase the reach of education.

Dr Pillai affirmatively says that IGNOU is determine to take the reach of education in most remote corner of country.